Check for updates

Nations and Nationalism

WILEY

ARTICLE OPEN ACCESS

Digital Nationalism in Comparative Perspective: Trump Blaming China on Social Media in the United States and China

Chris Chao Su[1] | Jun Liu[2,3]

[1]Boston University, Boston, Massachusetts, USA | [2]University of Copenhagen, Copenhagen, Denmark | [3]University of Cambridge, Cambridge, UK

Correspondence: Jun Liu (liujun@hum.ku.dk)

Received: 11 April 2024 | **Revised:** 1 May 2025 | **Accepted:** 22 July 2025

Funding: This work was supported by the Boston University's East Asia Studies Career Development Professorship and The Independent Research Fund Denmark—Sapere Aude Starting Grant (1055-00011B).

Keywords: China | comparative | computational methods | cross-platform | nationalism | social media | Trump

ABSTRACT

This study presents one of the first comparative analyses of digital nationalism on social media. Using a computational mixed-method approach—combining supervised, computer-assisted content analysis with network modelling—it analyses 64,541 tweets from Twitter and 91,063 posts from Weibo surrounding a shared geopolitical flashpoint: President Trump's blaming of China during the early stages of the COVID-19 pandemic. The analysis reveals not only divergent manifestations of nationalism over time but also distinct user roles and patterns of discursive engagement that exemplify contrasting sociopolitical contexts. Additionally, we identify less discussed cross-platform dynamics. The study makes three key contributions to the evolving field of digital nationalism. Empirically, it offers a fine-grained, longitudinal mapping of everyday nationalist expressions by diverse actors in specific sociopolitical contexts over a 9-month period (March–December 2020), capturing both temporal dynamics and nonelite perspectives. Methodologically, it advances a context-sensitive, inductive–deductive analytic strategy that supports the identification and comparison of nationalist discourses and the abstraction of the contextual conditions under which they emerge and circulate. Theoretically, the study deepens our understanding of digital nationalism as a contingent phenomenon, co-produced through the interplay of political cultures, user agency and media ecosystems—thus advancing a comparative framework attuned to the sociotechnical dynamics of digital nationalism.

1 | Introduction

'[T]he most momentous phenomenon of modern history' (Best 1982: 29), nationalism continues to command enduring interest across various disciplines (e.g., Billig 1995; Hearn 2020; Ozkirimli 2017). While media technologies are central to some seminal work on nationalism (e.g., Anderson 2006; Billig 1995; Deutsch 1966), the link between nationalism and digital media has developed into one of the most prominent issues in recent decades (e.g., Eriksen 2007; Fuchs 2019; Skey 2022). Concepts such as 'internet nationalism' (Eriksen 2007), 'digital nationalism' (Ahmad 2022), 'user-generated nationalism' (Shahin 2021), 'AI nationalism' (Goode 2021) and 'platform nations' (Mihelj 2023)—or, more broadly, 'new nationalism' (Schertzer and Woods 2022) that implies and interrogates the technological transformations of national identity—stand out to as frameworks to address the role of digital technologies in (re)shaping nationalism. These terms capture how 'nations transmute from physical to virtual matter—from geographical location to digital landscape' and how 'nations are produced and reproduced by common users online and are interpreted and reinterpreted in the process' (Shahin 2021: 1859).

This is an open access article under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-NoDerivs License, which permits use and distribution in any medium, provided the original work is properly cited, the use is non-commercial and no modifications or adaptations are made.

© 2025 The Author(s). *Nations and Nationalism* published by Association for the Study of Ethnicity and Nationalism and John Wiley & Sons Ltd.

Despite extensive scholarly attention, several gaps persist in our understanding of how (digital) nationalism manifests and evolves across contexts. First, comparative and cross-regional analyses of nationalism are needed to account for how divergent nationalist dynamics unfold across varying political, historical and regulatory settings (Lajosi and Nyíri 2022: 264). Mylonas and Tudor (2021) argue that without comparative research to 'helpfully dialogue with normatively oriented philosophy to empirically inform these debates' (p. 124), the study of nationalism risks treating it as a monolithic phenomenon, overlooking the fact that 'each country's national narrative is unique' (p. 112). Second, although existing literature recognizes the affordances of digital technologies in enabling bottom-up nationalist narratives, questions remain about whether quotidian user participation reshapes national imaginaries or whether digital spaces continue to be dominated—or even more easily manipulated—by state-led or elite-driven narratives. What role do everyday and quotidian user practices (Goode and Stroup 2015; Hearn and Antonsich 2018) play in constructing competing 'multiple nationalisms' (Bonikowski 2016: 441)? Third, the growing use of big data and computational methods in social science has yet to be fully harnessed in nationalism studies. As Skey (2022: 846) notes, these methods reveal 'a range of naturally occurring data' that support dynamic, large-scale and temporally sensitive analyses of how nationalism is expressed, amplified and contested in online environments.

This study addresses these gaps by offering one of the first comparative cross-regional studies of nationalism on social media. It examines content on Twitter and Weibo—two of the largest social media platforms—regarding the case of the US President Trump blaming China for the spread of the coronavirus (Viala-Gaudefroy and Lindaman 2020). Using supervised computer-assisted content analysis and subsequent statistical analysis of social media posts from Twitter ($N = 64{,}541$) and Weibo ($N = 91{,}063$), this study advances three key contributions. First, it provides an empirically rich, cross-platform and cross-regional comparison of digital nationalism and its transnational dynamics, further identifying contextual factors that shape these divergences. Second, it offers a longitudinal analysis of 'the diversification of actors taking part in the national (ist) discourse' (Ahmad 2022: 311), which reveals both temporal dynamics and nonelite perspectives. Third, it introduces an inductive–deductive analytic strategy with novel computational-assisted methods for exploiting and extracting contextually relevant elements from 'a range of naturally occurring data' (Skey 2022: 846) in comparative social media studies (Matassi and Boczkowski 2021). This methodological approach offers new insights into identifying and analysing context-bound national categories, preferences, and sensibilities in comparative studies of digital nationalism.

In the following sections, we first present a review of the discussion on digital nationalism and expound the comparative perspective, with an emphasis on understanding contextuality as a *relational* and *occasional* property (Dourish 2004: 22, emphasis in original). Second, we outline the methodology, including the case, data and methods of analysis. We detail our computational mixed-method approach—combining supervised, computer-assisted content analysis with network modelling. Third, we elaborate on how nationalism unfolds differently across specific social media platforms, in distinct ways, through various types of users, and with transnational implications. We conclude by reflecting on the broader implications of this study for comparative social media research and the scholarship on digital nationalism: empirically, by providing a fine-grained, longitudinal mapping of everyday nationalist expression across distinct sociopolitical contexts; methodologically, by advancing a context-sensitive, inductive–deductive analytic strategy for cross-platform comparison; and theoretically, by conceptualizing digital nationalism as a contingent phenomenon shaped by the interplay of political cultures, user agency and media ecosystems.

2 | Nationalism and the Digital

2.1 | Digital Nationalism in Focus

Extensive research has explored nationalism as 'a palpable political force' that 'has taken pride of place in the very centre of our politics, societies and culture' (Mihelj and Jiménez-Martínez 2021: 334; for reviews, see, e.g., Bonikowski 2016; Calhoun 1993; Mylonas and Tudor 2021; Skey 2022). While the relationship between media/technology and nationalism has been well acknowledged in the classic literature (Anderson 2006; Billig 1995; Deutsch 1966), Skey (2022: 839) points out that scholarly works on nationalism and the media have paid 'relatively little sustained attention' to each other's work. Arguably, the development of digital technologies—from websites to Usenet newsgroups, from email lists to blogs, and from social networking sites to digital platforms—has played a pivotal role in reviving nationalist discourse worldwide in recent years (e.g., Eriksen 2007; Fuchs 2019; H. Liu 2019; Mihelj 2023). Subsequently, as Ahmad (2022: 310) explicates, 'digital nationalism' emerges as 'a subfield of nationalism studies' that includes 'all forms of everyday, user-generated, and elite-driven nationalism which use the Internet and social media to create, sustain and project specific ideas of the nation and/or intend to mobilize support for a specific vision of nationhood'.

While several reviews and reflections on digital nationalism have provided comprehensive overviews of the field, three key issues warrant further interrogation in the scholarship on digital nationalism.

First, exploring digital nationalism across national contexts is crucial to understanding the *diverse* ways users 'represent a nation but also perform their national belonging' (Mihelj 2023: 13) in digitally mediated settings. As Marx (2005: 6) explains, nationalism encompasses both a 'collective sentiment or identity bounding and binding together those individuals who share a sense of large-scale political solidarity' and a sentiment 'aimed at creating, legitimating or challenging states'. Yet, such expressions of nationalism—or 'self-identification with and a sense of belonging to the nation' (Ahmad 2022: 310)—do *not* emerge in a vacuum. Despite the seemingly borderless nature of digital spaces, nationalist content is shaped by and reflects specific national contexts. So, if, as Skey (2022: 840, emphasis in original) argues, nationalism fundamentally raises the question of 'what and when is the nation?', then the digital arena becomes a critical site where this question

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

is constantly negotiated across contexts. A comparative approach therefore reveals digital nationalism's multiplicity and context-dependence. Rather than treating digital nationalism as a monolithic phenomenon, this approach foregrounds the question of 'how is nationalist digital content disseminated, translated, and transformed in various national contexts?' (Lajosi and Nyíri 2022: 265).

Second, it is essential to examine how digital technologies foster 'a multiplicity of voices and hence a diverse range of imagining and enacting the nation' (Mihelj and Jiménez-Martínez 2021: 337). Scholarship has emphasized that the participatory affordances of digital media can challenge the 'state-centred logic of nationalism' (Ahmad 2022: 308) by enabling nationalisms that emerge horizontally, peer-to-peer and—crucially—from the bottom up, alongside top-down narratives constructed and legitimized by conventional elites (e.g., Kaufmann 2017; Moreno-Almendral 2018; Yusupova 2018). Schroeder (2018: 60), for instance, describes digital media as 'a necessary precondition' for users to bypass traditional gatekeepers in populist nationalist movements. Schneider (2018a: 5) shows that 'national stories' are 'passively consumed but are actively constructed' through a dynamic interplay among authorities, commercial actors and internet users in China.

Yet despite these insights, existing research still 'privileges institutional and infrastructural analysis over the examination of audience practices and uses' (Mihelj and Jiménez-Martínez 2021: 342). As Skey (2022: 844) contends, 'relatively little of this work [on nationalism] has explored the extent to which the practices of ordinary users may be informed by [specific] national categories, preferences, and sensibilities'. More importantly, digital technologies do not exclusively empower subaltern voices. Authoritarian regimes and populist leaders have also strategically deployed digital platforms to disseminate and manipulate nationalist rhetoric that often reinforces exclusionary ideologies (e.g., Schroeder 2019; Waisbord and Amado 2017). Recent scholarship on information policy and infrastructure has raised further concerns about the rise of 'techno-nationalism'—the process of territorializing digital and moral boundaries, effectively transforming 'globally distributed information infrastructure into bounded national territory' (Möllers 2021: 112–113; see also Liao and Xia 2023; Schneider 2018a, 2018b).

This dual potential of digital platforms—supporting both decentralized pluralism and centralized control—raises a crucial question: To what extent do *diverse* users contribute to the emergence of 'multiple nationalisms' (Bonikowski 2016: 441), if any? Following Mihelj and Jiménez-Martínez's (2021) call, further research should prioritize bottom-up audience practices and everyday meaning-making processes through which individuals construct, negotiate and contest national imaginaries. Such a focus is essential not only for unpacking the complex processes through which national understandings are shaped but also for exploring 'how the interaction between media and nationalism changes over time' (Mihelj and Jiménez-Martínez 2021: 342) in digitally mediated spaces.

Third, computational methods are capable of exploiting the unprecedented volumes of digitized text produced through online interactions as new resources to map out nationalist beliefs. From public sentiment on social media to political campaigns (e.g., Bonikowski et al. 2022; Wu et al. 2024), these methods enable large-scale analyses that capture a breadth of nationalistic expressions *within* and *across* platforms. As Bonikowski (2016: 442) indicates, emerging computational methods offer 'the capability of bridging the divide between context-sensitive and distributionally oriented methods by simultaneously mapping communities of shared meaning, inductively tracking fluctuations in the salience of the nation, and examining the contextual predictors and sociopolitical consequences of the use of the nation as a category of practice'. Combined with 'a range of naturally occurring data' (Skey 2022: 846), these methodological advancements present invaluable opportunities for exploring how nationalist discourse spreads and transforms in digital spaces (see, e.g., Bonikowski et al. 2022).

Given this, we propose three research questions (RQs) to guide a comparative study of digital nationalism on social media. Our methodology, introduced in the next section, will address the computational challenges outlined above.

> RQ1: What are the differences in the emergence and diffusion of everyday nationalist expressions surrounding the same event, and which types of users are involved, as influenced by national contexts across different social media platforms?
>
> RQ2: In what ways do specific contextual factors prompt differences in nationalistic discourse on social media platforms?
>
> RQ3: To what extent is there a cross-contextual or cross-platform impact on the emergence and diffusion of nationalistic discourse between different social media platforms?

To clarify, while acknowledging the relevance of platform infrastructure and affordances (e.g., Ettlinger 2025; Schneider 2022; Zhang et al. 2024), our study instead emphasizes the explanatory power of various contextual differences in shaping variations in user engagement and nationalistic discourse.

2.2 | Identifying Context(uality) in a Comparative Digital Nationalism Study

Contextual explanation is essential not only for understanding the emergence, transformation and persistence of nationalism (Bonikowski 2016) but also for shaping 'the analytical perspectives and methodological choices of scholars studying nationalism' (Triandafyllidou 2022: 574). Although digital nationalism manifests through the use of the internet and social media, it remains closely tied to broader political, historical and social contexts that extend beyond digital technologies. To illustrate this, we next review a set of prominent contextual elements that shape nationalist expressions in China and the United States. These elements are not intended to be exhaustive but rather serve to highlight the relevance of contextual factors in shaping (digital) nationalism.

Among the countries studied in the context of (digital) nationalism, China stands out as one of the most extensively examined cases (see the review by Zhang et al. 2024). Although traditional

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

China did not historically embrace nationalism in the modern sense (Zhao 2000: 4), nationalism has since become a powerful force, shaped by a complex interplay of state control and individual agency. While dominant social actors such as the Party-state and opinion leaders often steer and seek to contain nationalist discourse, everyday forms of nationalism—reflected in individual practices—highlight 'the role human agency plays in reproducing nationalism' (Antonsich 2016: 40). These grassroots expressions of nationalism increasingly mirror official narratives and have contributed to the spread of xenophobia, Sinocentrism and anti-Western attitudes (Zhang et al. 2024: 1898).

Historical context is one of the most prominent factors shaping China's (digital) nationalism. This is evident in the digital 'remembering' of the so-called 'century of humiliation' and traumatic national experiences such as the 1937 Nanjing Massacre (e.g., Schneider 2018a, 2018b; Wang 2014). Cultural context is also influential. Nationalist discourse in China frequently revolves around debates over the revival or rejection of Confucian values, the importance of Chinese civilization and the preservation of cultural heritage as core to national identity. This tension between nativism and antitraditionalism has been further institutionalized through, for instance, discussions of state policies such as the 'Chinese Dream' (e.g., Bell 2014; H. Liu 2019). Geopolitical context is another influential dimension, particularly in relation to China's foreign and defence policies and its spatial-economic strategies like the Belt and Road Initiative, often framed through terms like 'geopolitik nationalism' (Hughes 2014) and 'new nationalism' (Rajaoson and Edimo 2022). Finally, the rise of digital technologies over the past three decades has introduced somehow greater narrative diversity, playful discourse and fan-driven engagements with nationalism—even if such expressions remain subject to state regulation (e.g., He 2023; Huang and Wang 2025).

Nationalism in the United States, however, exemplifies a notably different trajectory from many other contexts. Scholars have argued that the country's immigrant origins and multiethnic composition contribute to the notion that Americans 'are not a nation in the pristine sense of the word' (Connor 1978: 381). Subsequently, nationalism has been portrayed as distinct—even 'exceptional'—to nationalism elsewhere. It has been described as 'the political doctrine that dares not speak its name' (Lind 1995: 6), and even as 'a dirty word in the United States, viewed with disdain and associated with Old World parochialism and imagined superiority' (Pei 2003: 31). Yet, others argue that key features of American exceptionalism are themselves deeply nationalistic, manifesting in what has been called 'an absolute Americanism as old as the country itself' (cited in Lieven 2004: 22).

Scholars have also explored the historical context of American nationalism through various narratives and expressions of national identity, unity and patriotism (e.g., Brubaker 2004; Lieven 2004). A long-standing, though often overlooked, dimension of American political culture is, then, the ethnic context, which not only positions white majorities as central actors but also underpins the resurgence of both nationalist and populist movements—as well as forms of Black nationalism—across both offline and online spaces (Schertzer and Woods 2022: 54; also see Bonikowski and Zhang 2023; Bonilla and Tillery 2020).

In parallel to the case of China, the technological context in the United States enables political and populist leaders to bypass traditional media and speak directly to 'the people', while simultaneously allowing ordinary users—often under the cover of anonymity—to express and amplify nationalist sentiment (e.g., Gerbaudo 2014; Groshek and Koc-Michalska 2017).

While existing research has identified various contextual factors that shape nationalism and its digital manifestations, our comparative exploration seeks to move beyond simply confirming predefined categories. Instead, as illustrated in what follows, we acknowledge the value of *both* previously identified contextual factors *and* the lived experiences of citizens—often captured in concepts such as banal or everyday nationalism (Billig 1995; Goode and Stroup 2015; Hearn and Antonsich 2018)—that *may* give rise to forms of national belonging that are not readily categorized within established frameworks.

To guide our approach, we draw on Chaffee's (1991) framework for the explication of context (see also J. Liu et al. 2020) to emphasize the importance of developing plausible and flexible ways of *sensitizing* (Blumer 1954), identifying and theorizing the contextual dynamics at play in digital nationalism in comparative studies. As Blumer (1954) explains, a sensitizing concept 'gives the user a general sense of reference and guidance in approaching empirical instances', which encourages researchers to remain open to forms and patterns of digital nationalism not anticipated in advance.

Further, our study follows a tradition that treats contextual dynamics as interactional problems (Dourish 2004; Seaver 2015). As Dourish (2004, 22) explains, context is not a fixed container but a 'relational' and 'occasional' property—emergent and contingent upon specific social interactions and situations. This view allows us to treat comparison not just as a descriptive exercise but as a means of analytical clarification. As Hallin and Mancini (2004: 2, italics in original) note, 'comparison forces us to conceptualize more clearly *what aspects of that system actually require explanation*'. In this way, our study aims not only to characterize digital nationalism in different settings but also to systematically explore and theorize phenomena that may initially appear puzzling or inconsistent across contexts.

3 | Methodology and Methods

To address our comparative inquiries on the differences in nationalist expressions among various types of users, as well as the specific contextual factors underpinning these nationalisms across social media platforms, we propose an inductive–deductive approach to comparative studies of digital nationalism. The workflow outlines a five-step approach that combines qualitative insights with computational tools across the stages of (a) data collection and cleaning, (b) topic discovery with an inductive identification of nationalism-related issue topics, (c) human-guided coding and deductive refinement based on prior literature to annotate issue topics, (d) machine learning for large-scale classification and (e) network analysis and contextual comparison across platforms, time periods and user types. We begin with a description of the cases under study and then elaborate on each step.

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

3.1 | The Case

Using the American president Trump's blaming of China for the pandemic as a paradigmatic case (Flyvbjerg 2006), we compare nationalism on social media. As the coronavirus pandemic started to affect the United States in March 2020, President Trump blamed China for mishandling it and for secrecy about it (Rogers et al. 2020). The rhetoric, including terms like 'Chinese virus' and variants like 'kung flu' (Griffiths 2020), sparked widespread reactions and movements both online and offline that encompassed hostile anti-China sentiments, nationalist narratives in China and a 'narrative battle' over COVID-19 to counter the blame and defend national pride (e.g., Jaworsky and Qiaoan 2021: 295; Wang and Tao 2021).

Although Trump's remarks on China or the Chinese virus could arguably be considered deliberate and provocative, the antagonistic nationalism that ensued reflects broader discursive patterns (Seawright and Gerring 2008: 301). Rather, the case of Trump blaming China, among other cases (see Pei 2003; Schneider 2018a; Zeng and Sparks 2020), exemplifies such antagonism in nationalist discourse and sentiment between the United States and China and thereby entails generalization.

3.2 | Data Collection and Cleaning

Data collection started with a set of keywords related to the case of Trump blaming China, which were used to extract posts from the Weibo-COV-2 dataset (Hu et al. 2020, in Chinese) and a Twitter dataset harvested through the academic Twitter API (in English). We retained only posts from 18 March 2020 through 31 December 2020 (the end of the year) and applied filters based on the geotagged fields in the retrieved data. The starting date, 18 March 2020, marks the first time Trump publicly referred to COVID-19 as the 'Chinese virus' on Twitter, blaming China for the pandemic (Trump 2020). A total of 64,541 tweets from Twitter and 91,063 tweets from the Weibo-COV-2 dataset were included in the final datasets.

To track how nationalism evolved over time, we segmented the data into three phases: Phase 1 (March 2020) began when the event first occurred and became a trending topic on social media. Phase 2 (April 2020) represented a period of continued discussion and media engagement. Phase 3 (May 2020 and beyond) indicated a postevent phase with fewer posts, though certain themes remained prominent. This temporal segmentation aligns with both the unfolding of the event and the volume of social media activity, as illustrated in Figure 1.

3.3 | Identifying Nationalism-Related Issue Topics

To explore how nationalism is articulated online, we began by identifying 'the actual 'content' of the nation—about the distinguishing characteristics or identity of a nation, about who belongs to it and who does not, about what the national interests are and so forth' (Mihelj and Jiménez-Martínez 2021: 335). With two datasets, we applied a three-step approach. First, we employed Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA), an unsupervised topic modelling technique, to inductively identify significant issue topics from weekly data. LDA uncovers hidden patterns or 'topics' in unlabeled data *without* predefined, definitive attributes or fixed benchmarks (H.-T. Chen et al. 2020). Each issue topic was associated with 100 relevant terms, which helped us discern the general tendencies. Considering both statistical fit (i.e., semantic coherence and exclusivity) and the interpretation of topics, we set the number of topics (k) to 10.

Second, we incorporated human interpretation and theoretical grounding to label and refine the LDA-generated issue topics. Since nationalism remains relatively underexplored in network-based research, we cross-referenced existing literature

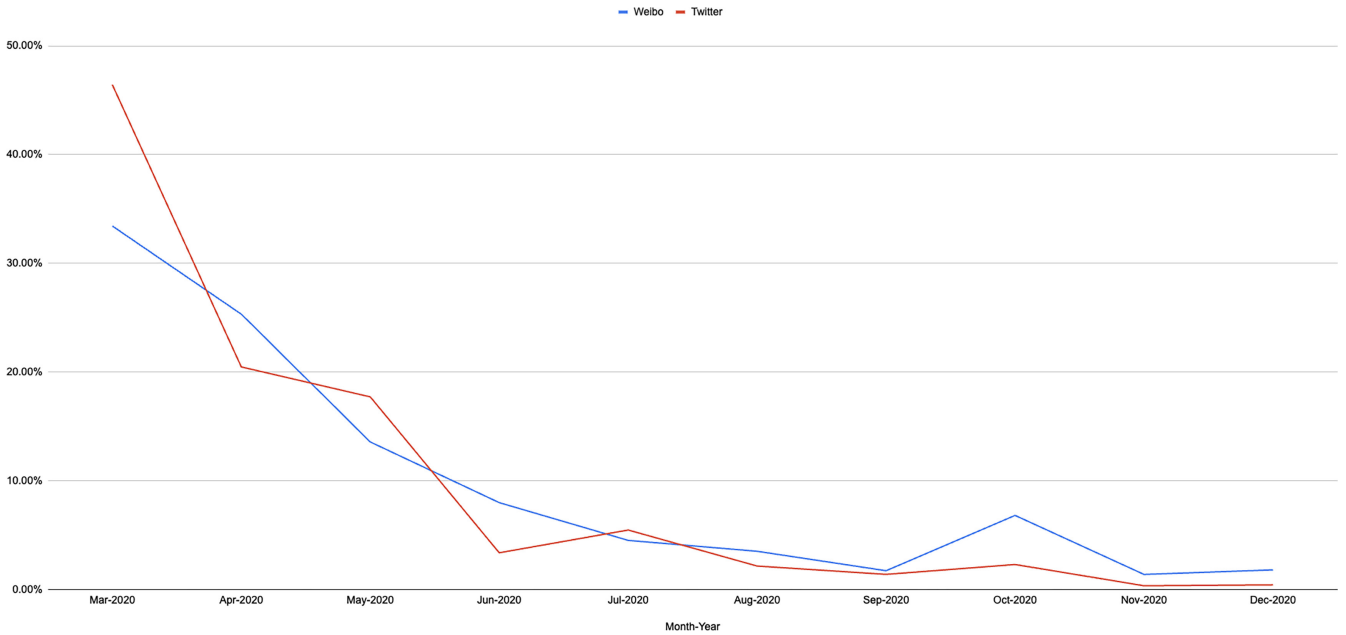

FIGURE 1 | Trajectory over time of the percentage of Weibo and Twitter posts mentioning Trump blaming China. [Colour figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

(e.g., Greenfeld 2012; Schneider 2018a) to create a theoretically informed yet exploratory list of issue topics. Weekly topic interpretations were conducted collaboratively by authors, and only clearly identifiable topics were retained. While grounded partially in prior research, this list remains open to contextual emergence, as our primary aim is to explore and compare contextual elements through the relationship among these issue topics rather than the categories themselves.

More specifically, we started with issue topics that relate to widely recognized themes in nationalism studies. First, national identification refers to a sense of belonging to a particular nation (Calhoun 1993), such as posts asserting 'We need to stand together as a nation now more than ever'. Second, historical narrative is often invoked to construct a shared national past (Guibernau 2013; Mylonas and Tudor 2021), such as mentions of the 'century of humiliation' or comparisons to '9/11' to justify present action. Third, we identified confident nationalism, characterized by the belief in national resurgence and support for the current regime (Oksenberg 1986), e.g., 'China has shown the world how to control the virus—unlike the U.S'. (original in Chinese). Another core dimension is the comparative narrative, as in 'America is falling behind while China rises' (original in Chinese), which views nationalism as inherently competitive—its prestige evaluated in relation to others (Greenfeld 2012). We also included two sentiment-based topic-issues commonly associated with nationalism (e.g., de Figueiredo and Elkins 2003): (a) out-group hostility, or negative sentiment toward outsiders or foreign groups (e.g., 'The virus is a bioweapon from China' or 'Foreigners brought this on us'); and (b) in-group affection, i.e., positive sentiment toward the in-group (e.g., pride or affection). Often reflected in people's daily attitudes and expressions, these sentiments or opinions are of importance to consider as part of everyday nationalism in the context of social media. Lastly, two attributes identified as significant in the literature—playfulness, for instance, memes mocking other nations while celebrating one's own, or sarcastic hashtags like '#ThanksChina' (also known as 'fun', humorous or ironic expressions of nationalism; see Udupa 2019) and criticism (e.g., dissenting or reflective voices; see Castells 2010)—are relevant in digital contexts and help capture the diversity of nationalistic discourse online.

We further included case-specific issue topics deductively drawn from the context of Sino-US tensions and the event of Trump blaming China. These issue topics captured key themes that repeatedly surfaced in both our computational topic modelling and qualitative review of the data. Examples included political incompetence (e.g., critiques of leadership failures, like 'Trump and the GOP want things to get worse since it strengthens their position from which to dole out Gov't. assistance in trade for allegiance!'); political divisiveness (e.g., US partisan conflict, such as 'Unable to actually govern, Trump and his minions just blame China or the Dems for anything that goes wrong'); racism and xenophobia; as well as discussions of COVID-19, economic concerns, US hegemony and victimization (the action, expression, comment on or singling out of someone or some group for cruel or unjust treatment). Though some of these may not traditionally fall under the scope of nationalism studies, they emerged as salient themes in our dataset and align with concerns raised in recent studies (e.g., Devakumar et al. 2020; Jaworsky and Qiaoan 2021; Lim 2021).

To clarify, we refined the list of issue topics through an iterative process that combined thematic relevance, empirical salience and weekly screening of topic modelling results to ensure analytical coherence and reduce redundancy. Several low-frequency or highly overlapping categories were either merged with broader themes or removed. For example, 'presidential behaviours' was subsumed under political incompetence, as it primarily captured critiques of leadership failure. Similarly, issue topics like prevention measures were integrated into broader COVID-19 discussions, while issues related to American global influence and control were folded into the category of US hegemony. Other topics—such as 'response from the Trump administration'—were removed due to consistently low frequency and limited analytical distinctiveness. The issue topics were refined through back-and-forth discussions among the authors until a saturation point was reached. Ultimately, this refinement process resulted in a final set of 15 issue topics, which provided a theoretically robust and context-rich foundation for our subsequent comparative analysis.

3.4 | Human-Guided Coding and Dataset Annotation

To connect the identified issue topics with real-world nationalist discourse on social media, we built an annotated dataset for content analysis and supervised machine learning. This step focused on evaluating how these issue topics appeared in posts related to Trump's blaming of China, across both Twitter and Weibo. Several rounds of pilot coding were conducted to ensure that the list of issue topics could be detected in both datasets.

We began by randomly selecting a sample of 2000 posts from each dataset (hereafter referred to as the 'sampled datasets'). These posts were manually coded by two trained students, who determined: (1) whether the post was related to the case of Trump blaming China; and (2) which of the 15 nationalism-related issue topics were present. Each post could be assigned multiple issue topics, with binary labels ('mentioned'/'not mentioned') applied to each. Several rounds of pilot coding were conducted to ensure consistent interpretation of each issue topic. The final intercoder reliability was strong: for Weibo posts, Krippendorff's α was 0.92 for the first question and 0.84 for the second; for Twitter, α values were 0.93 for the first question and 0.87 for the second, respectively.

3.5 | Machine Learning for Large-Scale Classification

Next, to scale up the classification of issue topics across the full datasets, we applied a supervised learning model based on BERT (Bidirectional Encoder Representations from Transformers; Devlin et al. 2018; see similar studies like Guo et al. 2023). For each prediction, we used BERT to generate vectorized text representations and trained a binary classification model for each of the 15 issue topics, as well as for post relevance. This allowed the model to learn from the annotated sample and predict topic

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

presence in the larger, unlabeled data. We evaluated model performance using 10-fold cross-validation. The results showed that the precision of the models was between 0.80 and 0.92 and the recall between 0.90 and 0.95 for tweets, while the precision was between 0.78 and 0.96 and the recall between 0.85 and 0.91 for Weibo posts. Finally, the 16 models were used to predict post relevance and the 15 issue topics for the remaining datasets.[1]

3.6 | Network Analysis of Topic Associations

To further explore the structure and diffusion of nationalism, we applied a network analysis approach to examine how issue topics were interconnected within and across datasets. We constructed matrices representing the co-occurrence of issue topics within the same social media posts. Each 15×15 matrix quantified the strength of association between every pair of topics, with weights reflecting the frequency with which two topics appeared together in a single post. For example, if 'collective identity' and 'political divisiveness' were mentioned together in 100 posts, their connection strength was recorded as 100.

We repeated this procedure for each pair of issue topics and for each matrix that we created. To map out the temporal evolution of nationalism discourse, we created separate co-occurrence matrices for each of the three phases: March (Phase 1), April (Phase 2) and May 2020 and beyond[2] (Phase 3). We also segmented the datasets by account types (e.g., individual, influencer and organizational) and post genres, allowing us to explore differences in topic associations across user categories (RQ2). To ensure comparability, each matrix was normalized by the total number of posts in its subset.

Account types were defined using platform-specific metadata and classification criteria, including verification status, account descriptions and follower count distributions, following established approaches in prior studies (e.g., Z. Chen et al. 2019; Freelon et al. 2020). On both Twitter and Weibo, we categorized users into three types: influencers, organizational accounts and individual users. Influencers were defined as users whose follower counts fell within the top 10% of all accounts on each platform. Specifically, for Twitter ($N = 1452$), influencer accounts had more than 6138 followers, while for Weibo ($N = 4233$), the threshold was 4547 followers. Organizational accounts were identified based on verified affiliations with institutions as indicated in profile metadata or bio descriptions. Individual users were defined residually as accounts that did not meet the criteria for either influencers or organizational accounts. These were typically unverified personal accounts with moderate to low follower counts and no clear institutional affiliation. Yet, we acknowledge that our classification did not account for automated accounts or bots, which, although outside the scope of this study, may play a role in amplifying or distorting the visibility and diffusion of nationalist content—particularly during high-attention political events.

To discover the contextual drivers behind these patterns, we used the multiple regression quadratic assignment procedure (MRQAP). MRQAP allowed us to gauge the unique effect of one independent matrix on a dependent matrix while accounting for the effects of other predictors (Dekker et al. 2007). For instance, to examine the influence of account type on the attribute network during Phase 1, we used matrices constructed from social media posts by individual, influencer and organizational accounts as independent variables and the overall attribute network of nationalism in Phase 1 as the outcome variable in MRQAP analysis. MRQAP generates *p*-values by randomly shuffling the residuals from the regression on each predictor (fixed effect).

4 | Results

4.1 | Descriptive Analysis

We first consider the distribution of account types across the two platforms. Based on account metadata in our datasets, individual users constituted the overwhelming majority of contributors—approximately 86% on Weibo ($N = 37{,}675$ out of 43,774 classified accounts) and 87% on Twitter ($N = 12{,}633$ out of 14,472 classified accounts). Organizational accounts represented a larger share on Weibo (4.2%) compared to Twitter (2.6%), while the remaining accounts were classified as influencers. These patterns suggest that while both platforms are primarily populated by individual users, Weibo exhibits a slightly stronger presence of elite actors, likely reflecting differences in platform infrastructure, content moderation and verification practices (e.g., Craig et al. 2021).

Between 18 March and 30 December 2020, the number of posts related to the Trump-blaming-China event declined over time on both Twitter and Weibo. Figure 2 shows that the majority of posts were concentrated in the first 3 months: 72.3% of Weibo posts and 84.6% of tweets occurred between March and May. A small increase in activity was observed in October, likely driven by the 2020 US presidential election and related debates (Griffiths, October 2020). These trends provided empirical justification for segmenting the datasets into three time periods.

To compare the evolution of issue topics over time (RQ1), we plotted the trend of posts on Weibo (Figure 2) and Twitter (Figure 3). On Weibo, we observed that COVID-19, out-group hostility and collective identity were the most prevalent issues topics over most of the months, followed by in-group affection, comparative narrative and political divisiveness. For instance, one Weibo user posted, 'The speech draft from Trump deliberately replaces 'coronavirus' with 'Chinese virus'. This is clearly intentional ...' (originally stated in Chinese and translated to English by authors)—a typical example of out-group hostility. Comparative narratives also emerged: 'President Trump said if the U.S. death toll stays under 100,000, they've done a good job. If it were China, they'd be criticized nonstop' (translated from Chinese), pointing to both political divisiveness and comparative framing. Playfulness was another prevalent issue topic on Weibo at the start, but its prevalence decreased over the first 2 months. Criticism (on average 0.7%) and historical narrative (on average 1.2%) were least discussed on Weibo. It is worth noting that comparative narrative saw an increase from May to June (from 6.3% to 15.3%), and in-group affection showed an increase from September to October (from 7.8% to 11.7%).

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

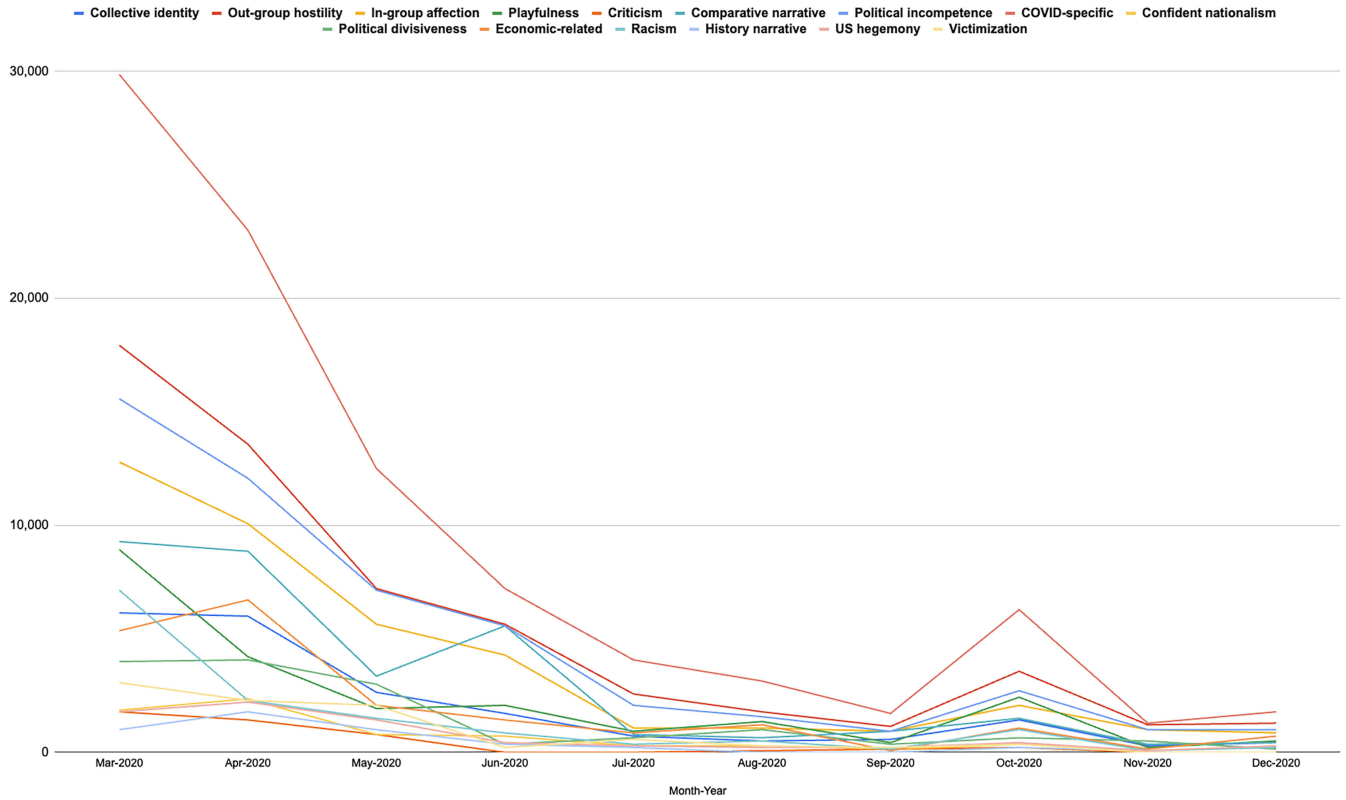

FIGURE 2 | Trend in issue topics in Weibo posts about Trump blaming China. [Colour figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

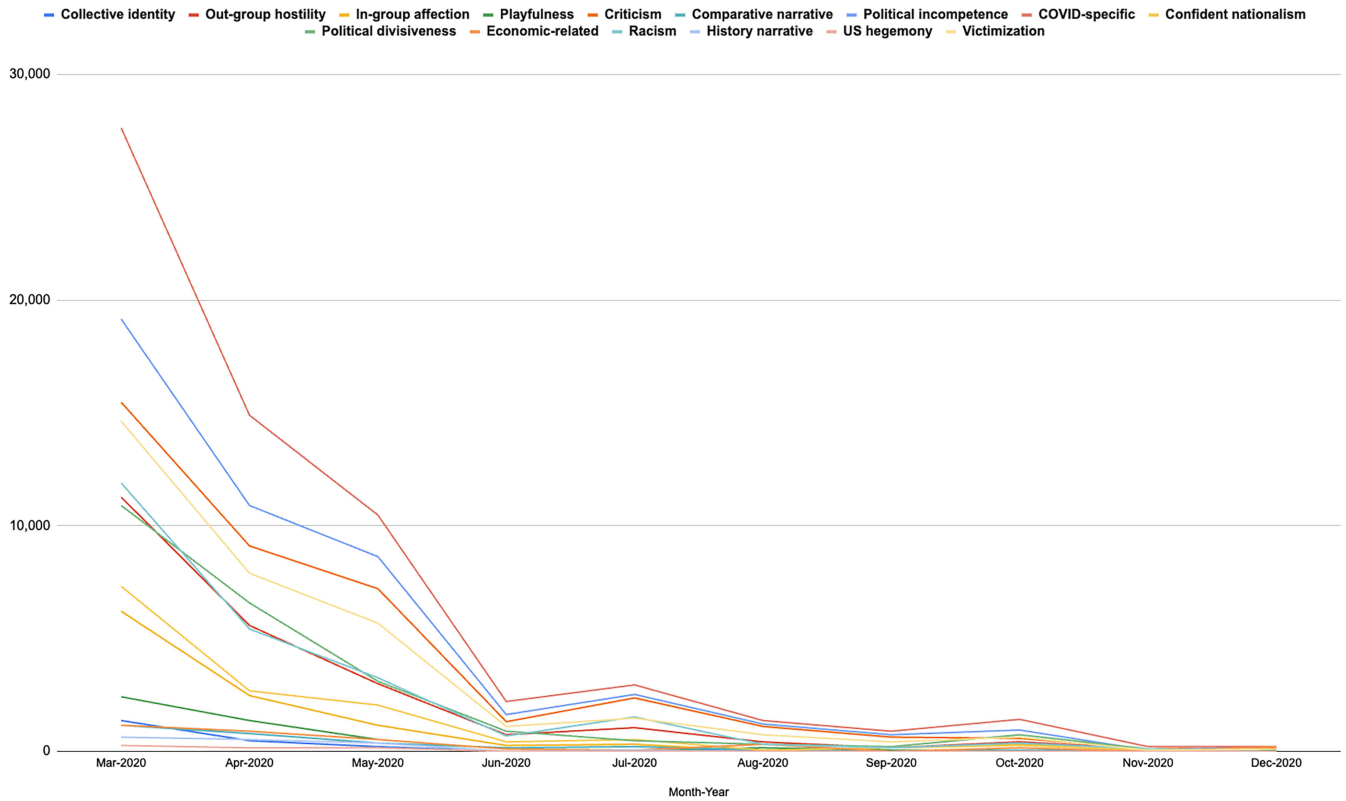

FIGURE 3 | Trend in issue topics in Twitter about Trump blaming China. [Colour figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

As for Twitter, the most prominent issues topics were those related to COVID-19, political incompetence, criticism and victimization. Examples include tweets such as: 'Another propaganda memo from the Republican Party. This country needs leadership, not spin', and 'Yes Schiff, we know you have no backbone for what Trump has done. Keep tweeting though,

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

it's cute'. The trend of tweets mentioning political incompetence increased dramatically in the months of September and October, likely due to the US presidential election. For example, one tweet from March stated, 'Please add one more step the Republicans & trump missed in the coronavirus response', pointing to perceived failures in political leadership. Similarly, there was a spike in tweets discussing criticism during this time. Out-group hostility also saw an uptick between October and November (from 7.0% to 11.8%). Economic concerns were also voiced: 'Wall Street and the Trump cronies win again while the middle class is left to suffer', highlighting the political economy dimension of the discourse. The least discussed issues topics on Twitter were those related to US hegemony, historical narrative, collective identity, playfulness, in-group affection and confident nationalism. However, there was a sudden increase in tweets surrounding collective identity in November (from 0.9% to 5.9%). Additionally, among all the tweets, economic-related tweets witnessed a sharp increase from 2.6% in October to 22.2% in November. One user wrote in April, 'This is how politicians like Trump and deBlasio bankrupt the city. Our taxes go to their ego plans', directly linking national leadership to economic fallout.

4.2 | Issue Topics From a Comparative Perspective

Figures 4 and 5 present the associations between different issues topics on Weibo and Twitter. Each node on the graph represents an issue topic and the lines connecting them indicate the degree of association between the topics. The size of each node represents the salience of the issue topic on the specific platform, while the colour represents the clustering of the issues topics according to their frequency of co-occurrence. In other words, nodes in the same cluster are more closely connected and frequently co-occur in the same social media posts, while those in different clusters are more distant from one another.

Three clusters[3] emerged from the issue topic networks on each platform, with remarkable differences across the two platforms. On Weibo, the most closely connected and dominant cluster involved COVID-19, in-group affection, out-group hostility, political incompetence, comparative narrative and playfulness. In contrast, Twitter's dominant cluster emphasized criticism and victimization, which did not appear at all on Weibo. Moreover, racism was tightly connected to out-group hostility on Twitter but more closely related to political divisiveness and the economy on Weibo. These differences suggest that national and political contexts significantly shape both the salience and structure of digital nationalism.

4.3 | Comparing the Diffusion of Nationalistic Discourse and Social Media Actors Involved

Next, to look comparatively into the emergence and diffusion of nationalistic content on Weibo and Twitter and the actors involved (RQ1), we used MRQAP to probe the effect of social media account types and post types on the formation of issue topic networks across the three phases. On Weibo, individuals and influencers significantly contributed to nationalistic discourse in Phase 1 (March 2020) ($\beta = 1.01$ and 1.27, respectively; $p < 0.001$). This suggested that grassroots and influencer/celebrity-level users were key drivers of early online nationalism. Reposts and comments/opinion-based posts also played a significant role, while organizational accounts and original posts had comparatively less impact. In Phase 2 (April 2020), the influence of organizational accounts increased markedly ($\beta = 1.10$, $p < 0.001$), along with continuing contributions from influencers and individuals. This

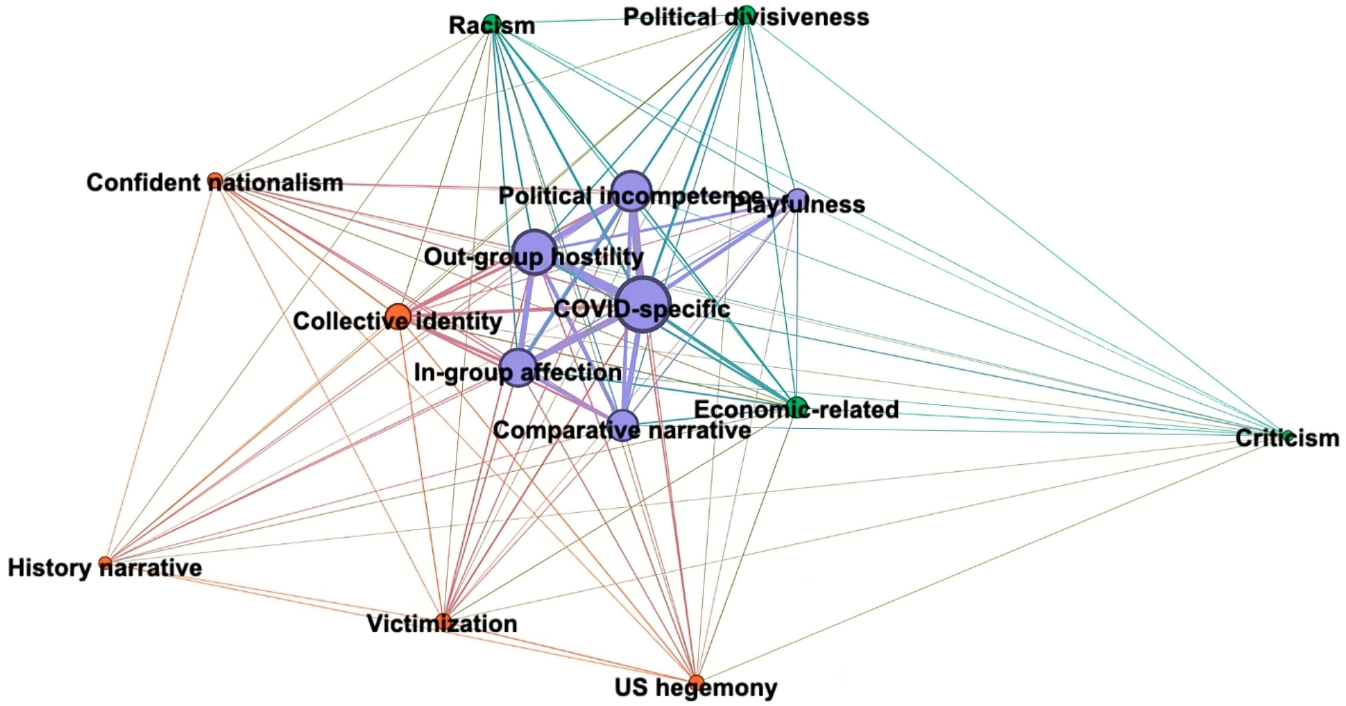

FIGURE 4 | Co-occurrence network of nationalistic discourse issue topics on Weibo. [Colour figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

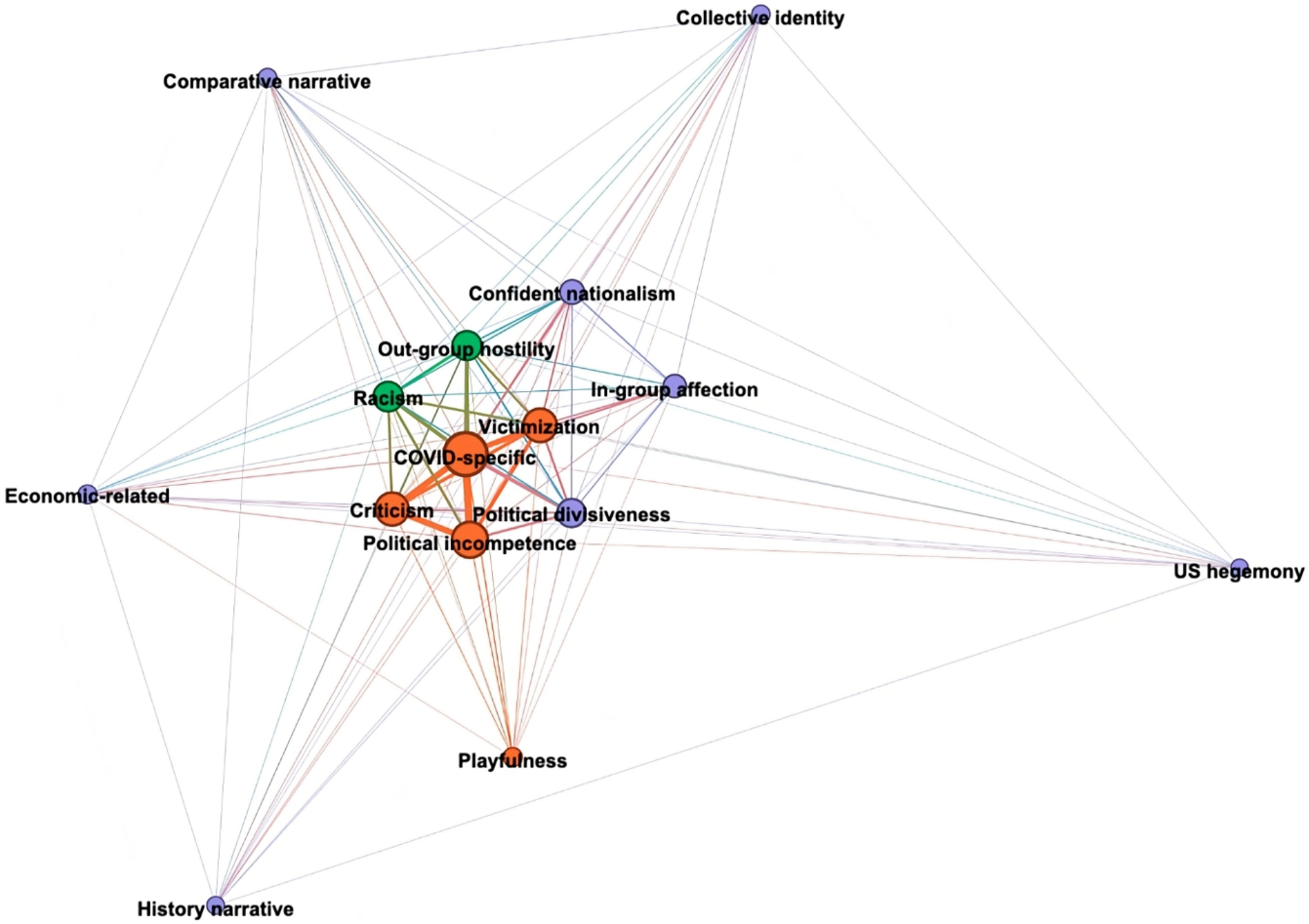

FIGURE 5 | Co-occurrence network of nationalistic discourse issue topics on Twitter. [Colour figure can be viewed at wileyonlinelibrary.com]

diversity indicated a broadened range of actors in shaping digital nationalism. Notably, original posts and reposts without commentary gained prominence, while user-generated commentary became less central. By Phase 3 (May to December 2020), individual accounts remained the primary contributors ($\beta = 0.98$, $p < 0.001$), whereas the influence of influencers and organizations declined. All three types of post—original content, reposts and comments—contributed to the discourse, further indicating a more diversified participation landscape in the later stage. Table 1 summarizes these dynamics.

On Twitter, individual accounts were the most consistent contributors across all three phases. More specifically, in Phase 1 (March 2020), individual accounts were the primary drivers of nationalistic discourse ($\beta = 1.07$, $p < 0.001$). Tweets containing user comments had a strong positive effect ($\beta = 1.22$), while original posts and retweets without commentary negatively impacted the discourse network. In Phase 2 (April 2020), a broader spectrum of users contributed to discourse formation, with both individual and influencer accounts showing significant effects ($\beta = 0.90$ and 0.13, respectively, $p < 0.001$). Moreover, all types of post—original tweets, retweets and comments—positively influenced the nationalistic discourse. Individual accounts remained central ($\beta = 0.91$, $p < 0.001$) in Phase 3 (May to December 2020), and organizational accounts also became statistically significant contributors ($\beta = 0.10$). Comments and retweets continued to fuel discourse, while the influence of original posts declined. Table 2 presents these results.

4.4 | Cross-Contextual and Cross-Platform Influences

To assess potential cross-platform effects (RQ3), we tested whether topic networks from one platform in prior phases could predict subsequent networks on the other platform while controlling for the attribute networks on the same platform. Results (Table 3) show that both Twitter and Weibo largely followed independent, platform-specific trajectories. However, cross-platform effects were minimal. The only statistically significant cross-contextual influence was a marginal effect of Phase 1 Weibo discourse on Phase 3 Twitter discourse (=0.13, $p < 0.05$).

As illustrated in Table 3, for both platforms, nationalistic discourse networks exhibited strong temporal continuity. For instance, Twitter's network in Phase 2 was significantly predicted by its Phase 1 network ($\beta = 0.98$, $p < 0.001$), and similarly, Weibo's Phase 2 network was significantly shaped by its Phase 1 structure ($\beta = 0.98$, $p < 0.001$). In Phase 3, the trend continued. Twitter's Phase 3 network was significantly influenced by both its Phase 1 and Phase 2 networks ($\beta = 0.17$ and 1.15, respectively), and Weibo's

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

TABLE 1 | Results of MRQAP analysis of the attribute networks of nationalism on Weibo.

Attribute network (IV)	B	β	Adjusted R^2
Phase 1: March			
Account genres			
Individuals	0.32***	1.01***	0.27***
Influencers	0.37***	1.27***	
Organizations	0.23	0.20	
Types of post			
Original posts	0.11	0.05	0.28***
Retweets	0.61*	0.12*	
Comments/ opinions	0.37***	0.93***	
Phase 2: April			
Account genres			
Individuals	0.16***	0.58***	0.32***
Influencers	1.21***	0.33***	
Organizations	2.12***	1.10***	
Types of post			
Original posts	0.78***	0.48***	0.30***
Retweets	0.15***	0.49***	
Comments/ opinions	0.21	0.05	
Phase 3: May and beyond			
Account genres			
Individuals	0.47***	0.98***	0.24***
Influencers	0.11	0.02	
Organizations	0.10	0.01	
Types of post			
Original posts	0.33***	0.13***	0.28***
Retweets	0.29**	0.11**	
Comments/ opinions	0.48***	0.87***	

Note: Unstandardized and standardized coefficients were reported.
*$p<0.05$.
**$p<0.01$.
***$p<0.001$.

TABLE 2 | Results of MRQAP analysis of attribute networks of nationalism on Twitter.

Attribute network (IV)	B	β	Adjusted R^2
Phase 1: March			
Account genres			
Individuals	0.48***	1.07***	0.25***
Influencers	0.09	0.05	
Organizations	0.27	0.04	
Types of post			
Original posts	−2.84***	−0.06***	0.26***
Retweets	−0.46***	−0.18***	
Comments/ opinions	0.66***	1.22***	
Phase 2: April			
Account genres			
Individuals	0.21***	0.90***	0.26***
Influencers	2.84***	0.13***	
Organizations	−0.25	−0.01	
Types of post			
Original posts	2.09***	0.08***	0.28***
Retweets	0.16*	0.12*	
Comments/ opinions	0.24***	0.81***	
Phase 3: May and beyond			
Account genres			
Individuals	0.30***	0.91***	0.27***
Influencers	0.06	0.001	
Organizations	4.52*	0.10*	
Types of post			
Original posts	1.75	0.05	0.25***
Retweets	1.30***	0.70***	
Comments/ opinions	0.11***	0.27***	

Note: Unstandardized and standardized coefficients were reported.
*$p<0.05$.
**$p<0.01$.
***$p<0.001$.

Phase 3 discourse was strongly influenced by its own earlier phases ($\beta=0.54$ for Phase 1 and $\beta=0.47$ for Phase 2, both $p<0.001$).

5 | Discussion

While the link between digital media and nationalism has attracted significant attention and generated a substantial body of research, several gaps remain in our understanding of the dissemination and transformation of everyday nationalist content by multiple actors in various national contexts (Lajosi and Nyíri 2022: 265; Mihelj and Jiménez-Martínez 2021: 337). Emerging computational methods offer opportunities to explore large-scale, temporally sensitive datasets of 'naturally occurring data' (Skey 2022: 846) to uncover the trajectory of nationalism in online environments. Moreover, single-country

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

TABLE 3 | Results of multiple regression quadratic assignment procedure analysis on the attribute networks of nationalism on Weibo and Twitter, and their cross-platform impact.

DV	IV	B	β	Adjusted R^2
Attribute network in Phase 2	Attribute network in Phase 1			
Twitter (P_2)	Twitter (P_1)	0.54***	0.98***	0.17***
	Weibo (P_1)	0.01	0.01	
Weibo (P_2)	Twitter (P_1)	0.04	0.08	0.13***
	Weibo (P_1)	0.78***	0.98***	
Attribute network in Phase 3	Attribute networks in Phases 1 and 2			
Twitter (P_3)	Twitter (P_1)	0.13*	0.17*	0.26***
	Twitter (P_2)	1.16***	1.15***	
Twitter (P_3)	Weibo (P_1)	0.11*	0.13*	0.04*
	Weibo (P_2)	0.12	0.03	
Weibo (P_3)	Twitter (P_1)	0.17	0.10	0.02*
	Twitter (P_2)	0.01	0.001	
Weibo (P_3)	Weibo (P_1)	0.74***	0.54***	0.28***
	Weibo (P_2)	0.82***	0.47***	

Note: Unstandardized and standardized coefficients were reported.
*$p < 0.05$.
**$p < 0.01$.
***$p < 0.001$.

studies dominate the current nationalism scholarship (e.g., Ahmad 2022; Mihelj and Jiménez-Martínez 2021; Schertzer and Woods 2022; Schneider 2018a), while comparative studies on social media have explored political participation, network features and affordances and digital diplomatic strategies, without paying much attention to nationalism.

To fill the gaps, our study starts by examining the differences of everyday nationalistic discourse across platforms and user types over time (RQ1). As indicated, the emergence and diffusion of everyday nationalistic discourse followed *distinct* trajectories across Twitter and Weibo as well as user types.

We start with issues topics on Twitter and Weibo. Although COVID-19 was the most discussed issue on both platforms, it was the only major commonality. Nationalism on Weibo reflected identity-making and exclusionary tendencies—manifesting as collective identity, in-group affection and out-group hostility—whereas on Twitter, quite differently, nationalism was often critical and directed at domestic governance failures (e.g., the US government's inaction during the pandemic; also see The Lancet Infectious Diseases 2020), including issue topics like political incompetence, criticism and victimization. This distinction reveals that government accountability and competence drive the evolution of nationalism in the United States, while identity-making, cultural sovereignty and exclusionary nationalism (Bieber 2022) are decisive in encouraging nationalism in China. Meanwhile, playfulness occupies a significant place in nationalism on Weibo but not on Twitter.

The actors involved in diffusing nationalism also differed on the two platforms. On Weibo, nationalistic discourse evolved from influencer-led framing in Phase 1 to institutional promotion in Phase 2 and grassroots engagement in Phase 3. In contrast, on Twitter, individual users consistently drove the discourse behind the formation of nationalism. However, their narratives were often contested, particularly in Phase 1. The role of organizations was relatively weak, while influencers played a more varied role in facilitating discussions on social media through different expressive approaches. Interestingly, on Twitter, increased organizational involvement in Phase 3 corresponded with a decline in nationalist discourse salience.

Which contextual factors, then, contribute to these divergences, as our RQ2 asked? The following disparate dynamics reflect the influence of contrasting politics and media ecologies in the two countries. In China, censorship and control mechanisms significantly influenced both the tone and structure of online nationalism. The dominant cluster of issue topics on Weibo presents a far less critical voice than the one on Twitter, which epitomizes how the pervasive political (self-)censorship in Chinese social media could mould even nationalist discourse that may favour the regime, partially because the Weibo user is aware of censorship and (re)posts 'under pressure' (L. Chen et al. 2013). Meanwhile, playfulness (Yang 2019; Stockmann et al. 2020), often absent from Twitter, emerged as a key expressive mode on Weibo—used by citizens to navigate and critique sensitive topics within China's uncertain and shifting boundaries of permissible expression (Stockmann et al. 2020: 248).

What surprised us, though, is that historical narrative—traditionally a cornerstone of Chinese nationalism (e.g., Gries et al. 2011; Schneider 2018a)—took on a rather inconspicuous

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

role in nationalism on Weibo. This implies that, without precedent in the cases of either COVID-19 or Trump blaming China, the nationalism on Weibo does not backtrack and embrace, for instance, perceptions of US threats (Gries et al. 2011). In contrast, US-based Twitter discourse was shaped more by civil contestation and polarization. Themes like political divisiveness and criticism were prevalent, with nationalism functioning as a lens for civic frustration rather than patriotic unity. This divergence in nationalistic tone and expression underscores the powerful influence of political structures and platform governance on public discourse.

Similarly, against the expectation that digital technologies and platforms could open up the possibility of diversifying nationalist dispositions and imaginings online, the involvement of various actors was also shaped by contrasting political contexts. Generally speaking, China's state-linked actors play a more visible and legitimizing role in facilitating nationalism on Weibo, while Twitter remains decentralized and contested. In the case of Weibo, the diffusion appears to hint at the possible influential role of organizational actors functioning as 'an extension of state power' (Shi and Cai 2006: 329), in potentially legitimizing and thereby fostering nationalist sentiments (also see N. Liu and Liu 2023). Such a role is *not* evident among organizations in the United States. The same issue is observed as the fact that the growingly influential role of original posts and reposts without commentary suggests a shift toward more formal or mainstream messaging, while user-generated commentary became less central to the discourse. In other words, in China's internet regulatory environment, unauthorized political mobilization, even (pro-regime) nationalism, may face certain political risks that impede further participation. Against this backdrop, the involvement of organizational users opens up significant political opportunities (J. Liu 2016) for nationalistic expression and contagion online. Hence, the organizational users on Weibo play a far more essential role and, more importantly, are a legitimating source for unleashing nationalism sentiment in China. On the contrary, early nationalist discussions on Twitter were shaped largely by public reaction and debate rather than top-down messaging, which exemplifies more widespread and multifaceted engagement. The fact that all post types positively influenced the nationalistic discourse reveals a sustained interest among the public and organizations, even as the discourse matured.

Lastly, addressing RQ3, we examined whether nationalism diffused across platforms and national contexts. While both Twitter and Weibo exhibited strong internal continuity—networks in later phases were shaped by earlier ones—cross-platform influence was minimal. The only statistically significant cross-contextual effect was a weak correlation between Weibo Phase 1 and Twitter Phase 3. This suggests that nationalism develops largely within distinct sociopolitical environments, with limited transnational diffusion *despite* the global nature of the event. Yet, this pattern may, in part, reflect the characteristics of our case: President Trump's blaming of China unfolded across two contrasting sociopolitical systems (the United States and China), on different platform ecosystems (X/Twitter and Weibo), and in different linguistic spheres. These differences likely constrained the cross-platform and cross-cultural circulation of nationalist discourses. Transnational diffusion would be more prominent in cases involving countries with similar political contexts, shared or interoperable digital platforms and common linguistic resources, which can facilitate the circulation and resonance of nationalist narratives across borders. Overall, the evidence points to high contextual specificity in how nationalistic discourse develops on social media.

In addition to empirical insights, as one of the first studies, our methodological approach combines computational methods with qualitative reasoning to analyse how nationalism manifests across social media platforms and national contexts. The inductive–deductive iterative process allows us to detect both emergent patterns and theory-informed dimensions of nationalism across platforms and national contexts. The integration of human annotation and automation further enables scalable yet context-sensitive analysis. Our approach hence resonates with the suggestion by Bonikowski and DiMaggio (2016: 951) against the assumption 'that respondents adhere to coherent ideologies that can be identified a priori'. Together, these tools allow us to comparatively uncover both emergent and structured forms of digital nationalism.

6 | Concluding Remarks

Besides digital technologies and platform infrastructures, contextual factors significantly shape how nationalism unfolds—this study pinpoints such dynamics and its influence on the manifestation and diffusion of nationalist discourse online. Our comparative study reveals not only divergent manifestations of nationalism across Twitter and Weibo but also distinct user roles and evolving patterns of engagement that exemplify contextually embedded dynamics. We further identify temporal dynamics and a modest cross-platform effect, suggesting some degree of interaction across national discursive ecosystems. Additionally, our proposed computational approach offers a *sensitizing* lens for detecting, extracting and interpreting contextually relevant elements for comparative social media studies, hence moving beyond reliance on predefined, deductive frameworks. In other words, instead of claiming which element(s) is or is not contextual, our analysis sheds light on why elements are contextually relevant to the case and in what way.

This study makes three key contributions to the field of digital nationalism. First, it advances comparative nationalism by providing a fine-grained, longitudinal mapping of everyday nationalist discourse across two contrasting platform ecologies, showing how sociopolitical contexts shape both the content and circulation of nationalist narratives. Second, it recontextualizes digital nationalism as a contingent, co-produced phenomenon—emerging from the interplay of political cultures, user agency and platform-specific ecologies—challenging assumptions of its uniform or transnational diffusion. Third, it contributes to computationally informed research by offering a mixed-method roadmap that bridges content- and structure-based approaches, which subsequently capture micro-level discursive dynamics alongside macro-level institutional forces. Together, these insights provide a sharper theoretical and methodological framework for examining how nationalism is articulated, mediated and transformed in digitally networked environments.

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

6.1 | Limitations and Future Directions

As a preliminary comparative exploration of digital nationalism on Twitter and Weibo, our study has a number of limitations that could point to further studies. First, we focused on a specific case of nationalism (initiated largely by President Trump), which would arguably be selection bias, thus limiting the expansion of our conclusions on a general scale. Nevertheless, our findings exemplify and subsequently remind us of the constraints of a deductive-only approach on predefined components that may fail to capture the full picture of comparison. In other words, one of our main arguments is methodological self-reflection that advocates being simultaneously open-minded and sensitizing in comparative studies. Further studies with multiple cases of different forms of online nationalism, or those combining social media infrastructure with their users' behaviours, would allow the observation of possible similarities and differences in relation to our case and generalization of the understanding of digital nationalism across different contexts.

Second, our focus on nationalism in a general sense may obscure variations among different types or modes of (digital) nationalism. While we by no means claim that there is a homogeneous culture of nationalism in either China or the United States, future studies should involve typologies of (digital) nationalism to portray a nuanced picture of nationalism on social media.

Third, the human-coded sample size is small compared to the BERT pretrained corpus, though our comparison between the results from the whole dataset and human-coded samples showed high consistency. More tweets on the subject could be manually coded in future studies to improve model performance.

Fourth, future research should consider bot detection techniques to more accurately assess the dynamics of genuine user engagement and the potential amplification of nationalist discourse. It is also relevant to consider the roles of influencers in nationalist communication, as emerging studies highlight how social media personalities can shape political sentiment (e.g., Z. Chen et al. 2019; Li and Feng 2022).

Final, the cross-platform influence identified in this study is largely more exploratory than explanatory. Longitudinal or mixed-method research designs (Mihelj and Jiménez-Martínez 2021), including interviews or surveys, could further illuminate how users perceive and engage with nationalism online.

Author Contributions

Dr. Chris Chao Su is an assistant professor of Emerging Media Studies at the College of Communication, Boston University, USA. Email: suchao@bu.edu. Dr. Jun Liu is an associate professor at the Center for Tracking and Society and the Department of Communication, University of Copenhagen, Denmark. He is a visiting fellow at the Department of Sociology, University of Cambridge, UK. Email: liujun@hum.ku.dk.

Endnotes

[1] We performed all statistical analyses on the human-coded samples as described in the subsequent sections to ensure the reliability of the machine learning results. Statistical results were consistent in the two datasets.

[2] The classification of phases in this study is the result of both inductive and deductive approaches. Inductively, it was informed by the observed distributions of social media posts and issue-attribute networks on Twitter and Weibo. Deductively, it considered contextual variations in the development of the event 'Trump Blaming China'. We contend that these divisions, corresponding with monthly intervals, provide a coherent framework aligned with both observed patterns and contextual developments.

[3] The Louvain modularity algorithm was used to detect clusters in Gephi.

References

Ahmad, P. 2022. "Digital Nationalism as an Emergent Subfield of Nationalism Studies." *National Identities* 24, no. 4: 307–317.

Anderson, B. 2006. *Imagined Communities*. 2nd Edn. Rev. ed. Verso.

Antonsich, M. 2016. "The "Everyday" of Banal Nationalism." *Political Geography* 54: 32–42.

Bell, D. A. 2014. "Reconciling Confucianism and Nationalism." *Journal of Chinese Philosophy* 41: 1–2 33–54.

Best, G. 1982. *Honour Among Men and Nations*. University of Toronto Press.

Bieber, F. 2022. "Global Nationalism in Times of the COVID-19 Pandemic." *Nationalities Papers* 50 1: 13 25.

Billig, M. 1995. *Banal Nationalism*. Sage.

Blumer, H. 1954. "What Is Wrong With Social Theory?" *American Sociological Review* 19, no. 1: 3–10.

Bonikowski, B. 2016. "Nationalism in Settled Times." *Annual Review of Sociology* 42, no. 1: 427–449.

Bonikowski, B., and P. DiMaggio. 2016. "Varieties of American Popular Nationalism." *American Sociological Review* 81, no. 5: 949–980. https://doi.org/10.1177/0003122416663683.

Bonikowski, B., and Y. Zhang. 2023. "Populism as Dog-Whistle Politics." *Social Forces* 102, no. 1: 180–201.

Bonikowski, B., Y. Luo, and O. Stuhler. 2022. "Politics as Usual?" *Sociological Methods & Research* 51, no. 4: 172–178.

Bonilla, T., and A. B. Tillery Jr. 2020. "Which Identity Frames Boost Support for and Mobilization in the #BlackLivesMatter Movement?" *American Political Science Review* 114, no. 4: 947–962.

Brubaker, R. 2004. "In the Name of the Nation." *Citizenship Studies* 8, no. 2: 115–127.

Calhoun, C. 1993. "Nationalism and Ethnicity." *Annual Review of Sociology* 19, no. 1: 211–239.

Castells, M. 2010. *The Power of Identity*. 2nd ed. Wiley-Blackwell.

Chaffee, S. H. 1991. *Explication*. Sage.

Chen, H.-T., L. Guo, and C. C. Su. 2020. "Network Agenda Setting, Partisan Selective Exposure, and Opinion Repertoire." *Journal of Communication* 70, no. 1: 35–59.

Chen, L., Zhang, C., and Wilson, C.. 2013. "Tweeting Under Pressure." Proceedings of the First ACM Conference on Online Social Networks, 89–100. https://doi.org/10.1145/2512938.2512940.

Chen, Z., C. C. Su, and A. Chen. 2019. "Top-Down or Bottom-Up?" *Journal of Broadcasting & Electronic Media* 63, no. 3: 512–533.

Connor, W. 1978. "A Nation Is a Nation, Is a State, Is an Ethnic Group Is a...." *Ethnic and Racial Studies* 1, no. 4: 377–400.

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

Craig, D., J. Lin, and S. Cunningham. 2021. *Wanghong as Social Media Entertainment in China*. Palgrave Macmillan.

de Figueiredo, R. J., Jr., and Z. Elkins. 2003. "Are Patriots Bigots?" *American Journal of Political Science* 47, no. 1: 171–188.

Dekker, D., D. Krackhardt, and T. A. Snijders. 2007. "Sensitivity of MRQAP Tests to Collinearity and Autocorrelation Conditions." *Psychometrika* 72: 563–581.

Deutsch, K. W. 1966. *Nationalism and Social Communication*. MIT Press.

Devakumar, D., G. Shannon, S. Bhopal, and S. Abubakar I. 2020. "Racism and Discrimination in COVID-19 Responses." *Lancet* 395: 10231–11194.

Devlin, J., M.-W. Chang, K. Lee, and K. Toutanova. 2018. 'BERT'. Proceedings of NAACL-HLT, Minneapolis, Minnesota, 2–7 June 2019: 4171–4186.

Dourish, P. 2004. "What We Talk About When We Talk About Context." *Personal and Ubiquitous Computing* 8, no. 1: 19–30.

Eriksen, T. H. 2007. "Nationalism and the Internet'." *Nations and Nationalism* 13, 1: 1–17.

Ettlinger, N. 2025. "Far-Right Transnationalism, Digital Affordances, and the Specter of a New Geopolitics." *Human Geography*. https://doi.org/10.1177/19427786251318633.

Flyvbjerg, B. 2006. "Five Misunderstandings About Case-Study Research." *Qualitative Inquiry* 12 2: 219 45.

Freelon, D., A. Marwick, and D. Kreiss. 2020. "False Equivalencies." *Science* 369, no. 6508: 1197–1201.

Fuchs, C. 2019. *Nationalism on the Internet*. Routledge.

Gerbaudo, P. 2014. "Populism 2.0." In *Social Media, Politics and the State*, 67–87. Routledge.

Goode, J. P. 2021. "Artificial Intelligence and the Future of Nationalism." *Nations and Nationalism* 27, no. 2: 363–376.

Goode, J. P., and D. R. Stroup. 2015. "Everyday Nationalism." *Social Science Quarterly* 96, no. 3: 717–739.

Greenfeld, L. 2012. "Democracy, Ethnic Diversity and Nationalism." In *Nationalism and Internationalism in the Post-Cold War Era*, edited by K. Goldmann, U. Hannerz, and W. Charles. Routledge.

Gries, P. H., Q. Zhang, H. M. Crowson, and H. Cai. 2011. "Patriotism, Nationalism and China's US Policy." *China Quarterly* 205: 1–17.

Griffiths, J. 2020. *Trump Has Repeatedly Blamed China for a Virus That Now Threatens His Health. This Will Make Beijing Nervous*. CNN. Retrieved from. https://www.cnn.com/2020/10/02/asia/trump-china-coronavirus-intl-hnk/index.html Accessed 11 April 2024.

Groshek, J., and K. Koc-Michalska. 2017. "Helping Populism Win?" *Information, Communication & Society* 20, no. 9: 1389–1407.

Guibernau, M. 2013. *Nationalisms Hoboken*. NJ John Wiley & Sons.

Guo, L., C. Su, S. Paik, et al. 2023. "'Proposing an Open-Sourced Tool for Computational Framing Analysis of Multilingual Data' Digital." *Journalism* 11 2: 276 97.

Hallin, D. C., and P. Mancini. 2004. *Comparing Media Systems*. Cambridge University Press.

He, R. 2023. "Hashtag Nationalism." *Media, Culture & Society* 45, no. 7: 1471–1488.

Hearn, J., and M. Antonsich. 2018. "Theoretical and Methodological Considerations for the Study of Banal and Everyday Nationalism." *Nations and Nationalism* 24, no. 3: 594–605.

Hearn J. S. 2020 Rethinking Nationalism London Bloomsbury.

Hu, Y., H. Huang, A. Chen, and X.-L. Mao. 2020. "Weibo-COV." In *Proceedings of the 1st Workshop on NLP for COVID-19 (Part 2) at EMNLP 2020*. Association for Computational Linguistics. https://aclanthology.org/2020.nlpcovid19-2.34 Accessed 11 April 2024.

Huang, C., and H. Wang. 2025. "'Digital Panda Nationalism' Discourse." *Context & Media* 65: 100869.

Hughes, C. 2014. "Reclassifying Chinese Nationalism: The Geopolitik Turn." In *The Construction of Chinese Nationalism in the Early 21st Century: Domestic Sources and International Implications*, edited by P. Gries and S. Rosen. Routledge.

Jaworsky, B. N., and R. Qiaoan. 2021. "The Politics of Blaming." *Journal of Chinese Political Science* 26: 295–315.

Kaufmann, E. 2017. "Complexity and Nationalism." *Nations and Nationalism* 23, no. 1: 6–25.

Lajosi, K., and P. Nyíri. 2022. "Introduction: The Transnational Circulation of Digital Nationalism." *Nations and Nationalism* 28, no. 1: 263–266.

Li, X., and J. Feng. 2022. "Influenced or to Be Influenced: Engaging Social Media Influencers in Nation Branding Through the Lens of Authenticity." *Global Media and China* 7, no. 12: 219–240.

Liao, S., and G. Xia. 2023. "Consumer Nationalism in Digital Space." *Convergence* 29, no. 6: 1535–1554.

Lieven, A. 2004. "In the Mirror of Europe." *Current History* 103, no. 671: 99–106.

Lim, Y. J. 2021. "Nationalism Not Racism." *Texas Speech Communication Journal* 45: 85 98.

Lind, M. 1995. "Prescriptions for a New National Democracy." *Political Science Quarterly* 110, no. 4: 563–586.

Liu, H. 2019. *From Cyber-Nationalism to Fandom Nationalism*. Routledge.

Liu, J. 2016. "Digital Media, Cycle of Contention, and Sustainability of Environmental Activism: The Case of Anti-PX Protests in China." *Mass Communication and Society* 19, no. 5: 604–625. https://doi.org/10.1080/15205436.2016.1203954.

Liu, J., X. Liu, and K. B. Jensen. 2020. "Comparative Media Studies in the Digital Age." *International Journal of Communication* 14: 5754–5760.

Liu, N., and J. Liu. 2023. "Leading With Hearts and Minds." *Social Movement Studies* 22, no. 5–6: 728–750.

Marx, A. W. 2005. *Faith in Nation*. Oxford University Press.

Matassi, M., and P. Boczkowski. 2021. "An Agenda for Comparative Social Media Studies." *International Journal of Communication* 15: 207–228.

Mihelj, S. 2023. "Platform Nations." *Nations and Nationalism* 29 1: 10 24.

Mihelj, S., and C. Jiménez-Martínez. 2021. "Digital Nationalism." *Nations and Nationalism* 27, no. 2: 331–346.

Möllers, N. 2021. "Making Digital Territory." *Science, Technology, & Human Values* 46, no. 1: 112–138.

Moreno-Almendral, R. 2018. "Reconstructing the history of Nationalist Cognition and Everyday Nationhood From Personal Accounts." *Nations and Nationalism* 24 3: 648 68.

Mylonas, H., and M. Tudor. 2021. "Nationalism." *Annual Review of Political Science* 24: 109–132.

Oksenberg, M. 1986. "China's confident nationalism." *Foreign Affairs* 65, no. 3: 501–523.

Ozkirimli U. 2017. Theories of Nationalism London Bloomsbury.

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

Pei, M. 2003. "The Paradoxes of American Nationalism." *Foreign Policy* 136: 30–37. https://foreignpolicy.com/2009/11/02/the-paradoxes-of-american-nationalism/.

Rajaoson, J., and R. M. M. Edimo. 2022. *New Nationalisms and China's Belt and Road Initiative*. Cham Springer.

Rogers, K., L. Jakes, and A. Swanson. 2020. "Trump Defends Using "Chinese Virus" Label, Ignoring Growing Criticism." New York Times. https://www.nytimes.com/2020/03/18/us/politics/china-virus.html.

Schertzer, R. S., and E. T. Woods. 2022. *The New Nationalism in America and Beyond*. Oxford University Press.

Schneider, F. 2018a. *China's Digital Nationalism Oxford*. Oxford University Press.

Schneider, F. 2018b. "Mediated Massacre." *Journal of Asian Studies* 77, no. 2: 429–452.

Schneider, F. 2022. "Emergent Nationalism in China's Sociotechnical Networks." *Nations and Nationalism* 28 1: 267 85.

Schroeder, R. 2018. *Social Theory After the Internet*. UCL Press.

Schroeder, R. 2019. "Digital Media and the Entrenchment of Right-Wing Populist Agendas." *Social Media+Society* 5: 4.

Seaver, N. 2015. "The Nice Thing About Context Is That Everyone Has It." *Media, Culture & Society* 37, no. 7: 1101–1109.

Seawright, J., and J. Gerring. 2008. "Case Selection Techniques in Case Study Research." *Political Research Quarterly* 61, no. 2: 294–308. https://doi.org/10.1177/1065912907313077.

Shahin, S. 2021. "User-Generated Nationalism." *Information, Communication & Society* 24, no. 13: 1854–1869.

Shi, F., and Y. Cai. 2006. "Disaggregating the State: Networks and Collective Resistance in Shanghai." *The China Quarterly* 186: 314–332. https://doi.org/10.1017/s0305741006000178.

Skey, M. 2022. "Nationalism and Media." *Nationalities Papers* 50, no. 5: 839–849.

Stockmann, D., T. Luo, and M. Shen. 2020. "Designing Authoritarian Deliberation." *Democratization* 27, no. 2: 243–264.

The Lancet Infectious Diseases. 2020. "The COVID-19 Infodemic." *Lancet* 20, no. 8: 875.

Triandafyllidou, A. 2022. "Contextualising Nationalism." *Ethnicities* 22, no. 4: 573–588.

Trump, D. 2020. 'The Onslaught of the Chinese Virus Is Not Your Fault! Will Be Stronger Than Ever!' @realDonaldTrump, Twitter. 18 March 2024. https://twitter.com/realDonald Trump/status/1240226752447873027?s=20. (Accessed 11 April 2024).

Udupa, S. 2019. "'Nationalism in the Digital Age' International." *Journal of Communication* 13: 3143–3163.

Viala-Gaudefroy, J., and D. Lindaman. 2020. "Donald Trump's "Chinese Virus"." Conversation, 21 April 2020. https://theconversation.com/donald-trumps-chinese-virus-the-politics-of-naming-136796.

Waisbord, S., and A. Amado. 2017. "Populist Communication by Digital Means." *Information, Communication & Society* 20, no. 9: 1330–1346.

Wang, Z., and Y. Tao. 2021. "Many Nationalisms, One Disaster." *Journal of Chinese Political Science* 26, no. 3: 525–548.

Wang, Z. 2014. *Never Forget National Humiliation*. Columbia University Press.

Wu, X.-K., G. Gu, T.-T. Xie, T. F. Zhao, and C. Min. 2024. "Unveiling Evolving Nationalistic Discourses on Social Media." *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications* 11, no. 1: 1–12.

Yang, G. 2019. "Performing Cyber-Nationalism in Twenty-First-Century China." In *From Cyber-Nationalism to Fandom Nationalism*, edited by H. Liu. Routledge.

Yusupova, G. 2018. "Cultural Nationalism and everyday Resistance in an Illiberal Nationalising State." *Nations and Nationalism* 24, no. 3: 624–647.

Zeng, W., and C. Sparks. 2020. "Popular Nationalism." *International Communication Gazette* 82, no. 1: 26–41.

Zhang, X., D. Dumitrica, and J. Jansz. 2024. "'Mapping Chinese Digital Nationalism' International." *Journal of Communication* 18: 22.

Zhao, S. 2000. "Chinese Nationalism and Its International Orientations." *Political Science Quarterly* 115, no. 1: 1–33.

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

Appendix A

Codebook and operational definitions of issue topics.

Issue topics in English	Definition in English	Issue topics in Chinese	Elaboration	Sources
Collective identity/ identification	Identification with the nation and being proud of the country (nation or state), or any words implying classification of in- and out-group	集体意识	国家身份认同和集体意识, 例如涉及到祖国、中国之魂、中国国旗、祖国\母亲、后盾\力量、依靠感、、归属、五星红旗、民族、China、中华民族、华夏 、庆幸生在中国;等	Both topic modelling and literature
Negative sentiment: out-group hostility	A negative attitude or expression toward anyone or any organization that is not part of a nation or country; dislike of or prejudice against people from other countries	排外/仇外主义/对外国势力的负面情绪	西方暴行、侵略、殖民、利益、或嘲讽美国等抗疫不力; 对非本国人民的排斥心态和言论	Both topic modelling and literature
Positive sentiment: in-group affection	Positive attitudes or expressions toward oneself, the country/nation or a group of one's peers	对自我群体的强烈正面感情	任何带有对本国人民、本国政府、本国文化强烈正面情绪 (不允许批判或质疑)的言论或表述	Both topic modelling and literature
Playfulness and enjoyment	Using a playful tone in a post, comment or expression, or relating to any statement that is entertaining or joking	娱乐性质	任何带有娱乐性质的表述 (好玩、开玩笑、娱乐圈、粉圈等)	Literature
Critics of nationalistic activism (voices of resistance)	Any attitude deviating from the mainstream positive attitude toward nationalistic issues, such as criticism and satire, doubt and concern or other reflections	对国家主义行为的批判	任何对于国家主义或者主流国家为先言论的批判或批判的态度 (比如讥讽、怀疑、担忧等其他相关的态度和言论)	Both topic modelling and literature
Comparative narrative (comparing China and the United States)	Expressions or statements that compare China and the United States	比较叙事 (对比中美)	任何对于中美两国 (人民、制度、政府、文化等)相关的比较	Literature
Political incompetence	Criticizing political figures, political parties, or administrations because they are unable to do their jobs or tasks properly	对政治无能的表述/言论	对政治人物、政治团体、政府行政机构的无能表现的批评和表述	Literature (context-based)
COVID-specific (measures, preventions, information, etc.)	Anything related to COVID-19 or the COVID-19 pandemic	新冠相关的内容或信息	任何跟新冠相关/新冠疫情的言论或信息	Topic modelling
Confident nationalism/ complementary attitude	A complementary attitude toward the country or the government, as well as confidence in the greatness of the nation and the leadership	对国家机器的赞美态度	一般需要有正面形容词或赞美之词 如 强大的祖国, 若仅有 为祖国骄傲, 则归为1. e.g., 以民为本、致敬、可爱、可敬、全心全意为人民服务、万岁、强大, 坚强的后盾\崛起、国之强大、国力	Both topic modelling and literature
Political divisiveness	Something that is divisive causes unfriendliness and arguments between people, particularly relating to partisanship in the United States	政治分裂	不同政治派别之间的差异和分别, 或者反映出不同政治派别之间的难以协调, 例如改革派和保守派、开放派和封锁派	Literature (context-based)
Economic-related	Any posts, comments or criticisms involving the economy or economic issues	经济相关的表述	任何提到经济、市场、经济发展、贸易等相关的表述或内容	Topic modelling

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/hana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License

Issue topics in English	Definition in English	Issue topics in Chinese	Elaboration	Sources
Racism	A statement or expression that demonstrates prejudice, discrimination or antagonism against individuals, communities or institutions based on their membership of a minority or marginalized group	种族主义	任何跟歧视、偏见、挑起种族或民族对对立的言论或态度, 尤其基于群体间生物、文化、习惯差异而言的	Literature (context-based)
History narrative	Refers to history—i.e., failure or glory in the past; make the United States great again	历史相关的表述	任何提到历史相关的表述、态度, 例如伟大复兴、大明等	Literature
US hegemony	Any posts, comments or criticism involving the statement that the United States has a dominant military, economic and political position over the rest of the world	美国霸权	关于美国在军事、经济、或者政治地位上强于并优于, 甚至统治世界上其他国家或地区的言论、评论、和批评	Topic modelling
Victimization	An action, expression or comment singling out someone or some group for cruel or unjust treatment—for example, people in the United States are the victims of the COVID-19 virus	关于“受害者”的表述	任何提到受害、被害、被迫害等相关的表述, 例如美军偷渡、军运会等	Topic modelling

14698129, 0, Downloaded from https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1111/nana.70025 by Louisiana State University, Wiley Online Library on [09/10/2025]. See the Terms and Conditions (https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/terms-and-conditions) on Wiley Online Library for rules of use; OA articles are governed by the applicable Creative Commons License